

THE
SOUL
OF THE
FOREST



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The Soul of the Forest

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THIS BOOK IS ABOUT
Me and Mumma,
WHO IS ALWAYS KIND AND GIVING.

SOMETIMES SHE FORGETS
TO LOOK AFTER HERSELF.

THIS BOOK IS A GIFT
TO MUMMA
ON MOTHER'S DAY.



These friends also show different parts of me.

I am like Dottie when I need sleep to feel better, like Mona when I am laughing and playing with my friends, like Nancy when I am tired or hungry and my feelings become too big, and like Knotty when I feel anxious and tied up inside. Voz is the happiest, truest part of me: the part that wants to sing, smile, and enjoy being a kid.



THE CHARACTERS

Cherry Jerry, the cherry tree

A magical cherry tree covered in colorful cherries. She looks after everybody in the forest the way a mother looks after her family. Her shade, fruit, shelter, and warmth make the forest feel like home.

Voz the bird

Voz means “voice” in Spanish. She loves to sing, dance, and fly high into the sky. She feels deeply sometimes sad, sometimes scared, sometimes brave. When she remembers who she is and where she comes from, she finds the courage to help others. This is her story too, about a small bird who discovers that she was never too small to make a difference.

Dottie the giraffe

Dottie is kind, funny, and fond of berries. She is so tall that she notices things the others miss, and she can even sleep while standing.

Mona the monkey

Mona is playful, energetic, and always on the move. She swings from branches, loves being with friends, and seems as if she never needs to sleep.

Nancy the rabbit

Nancy can become very grumpy when she is tired or hungry. When her feelings get too big, she wants to jump, stomp, or chew on something until she feels calmer.

Knotty the snake

Knotty is playful and clever, but when he feels anxious, his body twists and curls into knots. With patience, reassurance, and help from the people who care about him, he slowly learns to straighten himself out.

Bumpy the camel

Bumpy is strong, patient, generous, and kind. His hump seems to carry everything: food, useful things, and sometimes a whole mountain of thoughts.

Once, in a magical forest, there lived a cherry tree that grew every day. It grew and grew and grew, stretching toward the clouds. The animals fondly called her **Cherry Jerry**.

She was taller than the Burj Khalifa, brighter than the morning sun, and infinitely more colorful than a double rainbow after a summer storm.

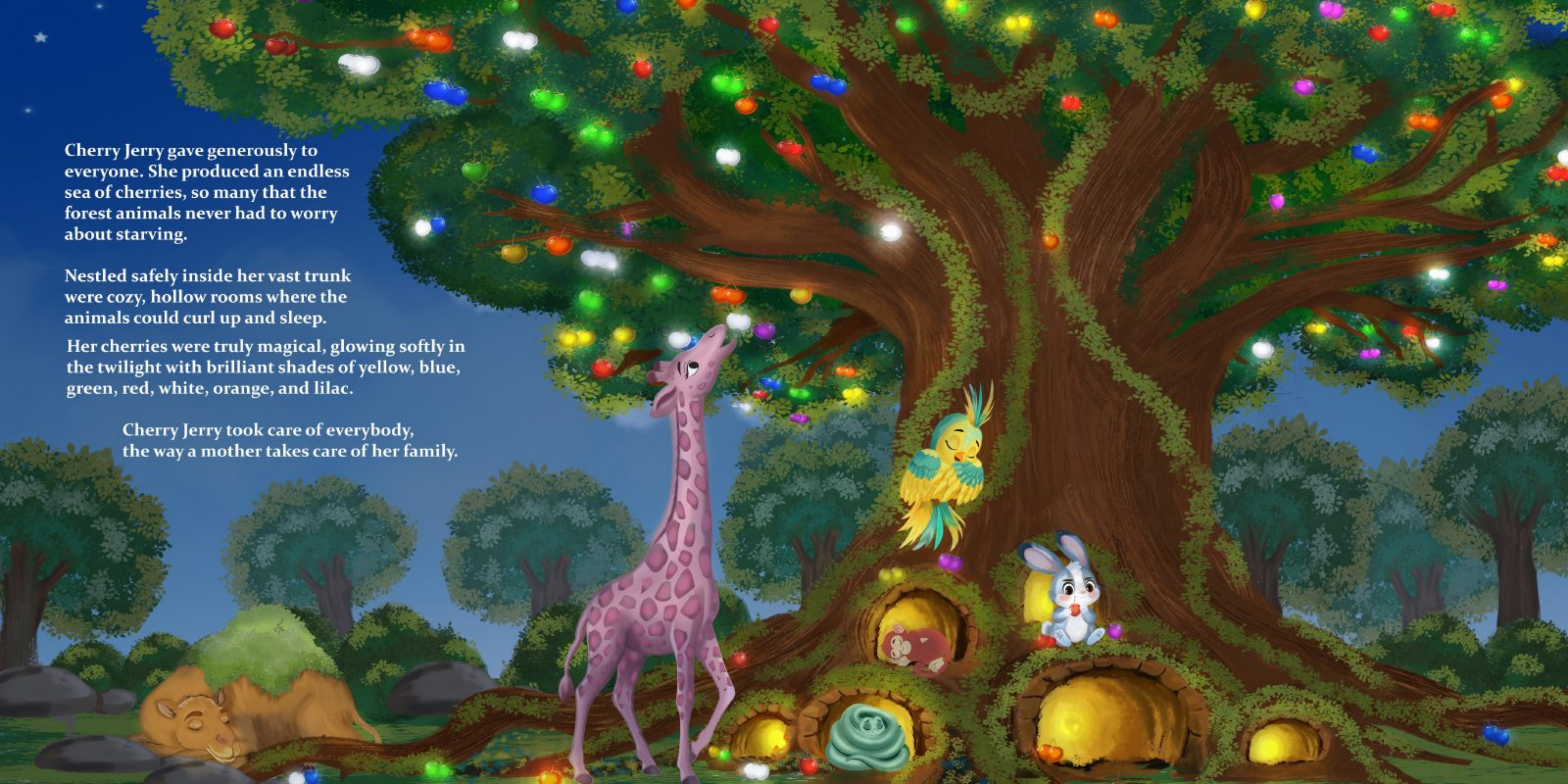


Cherry Jerry gave generously to everyone. She produced an endless sea of cherries, so many that the forest animals never had to worry about starving.

Nestled safely inside her vast trunk were cozy, hollow rooms where the animals could curl up and sleep.

Her cherries were truly magical, glowing softly in the twilight with brilliant shades of yellow, blue, green, red, white, orange, and lilac.

Cherry Jerry took care of everybody, the way a mother takes care of her family.

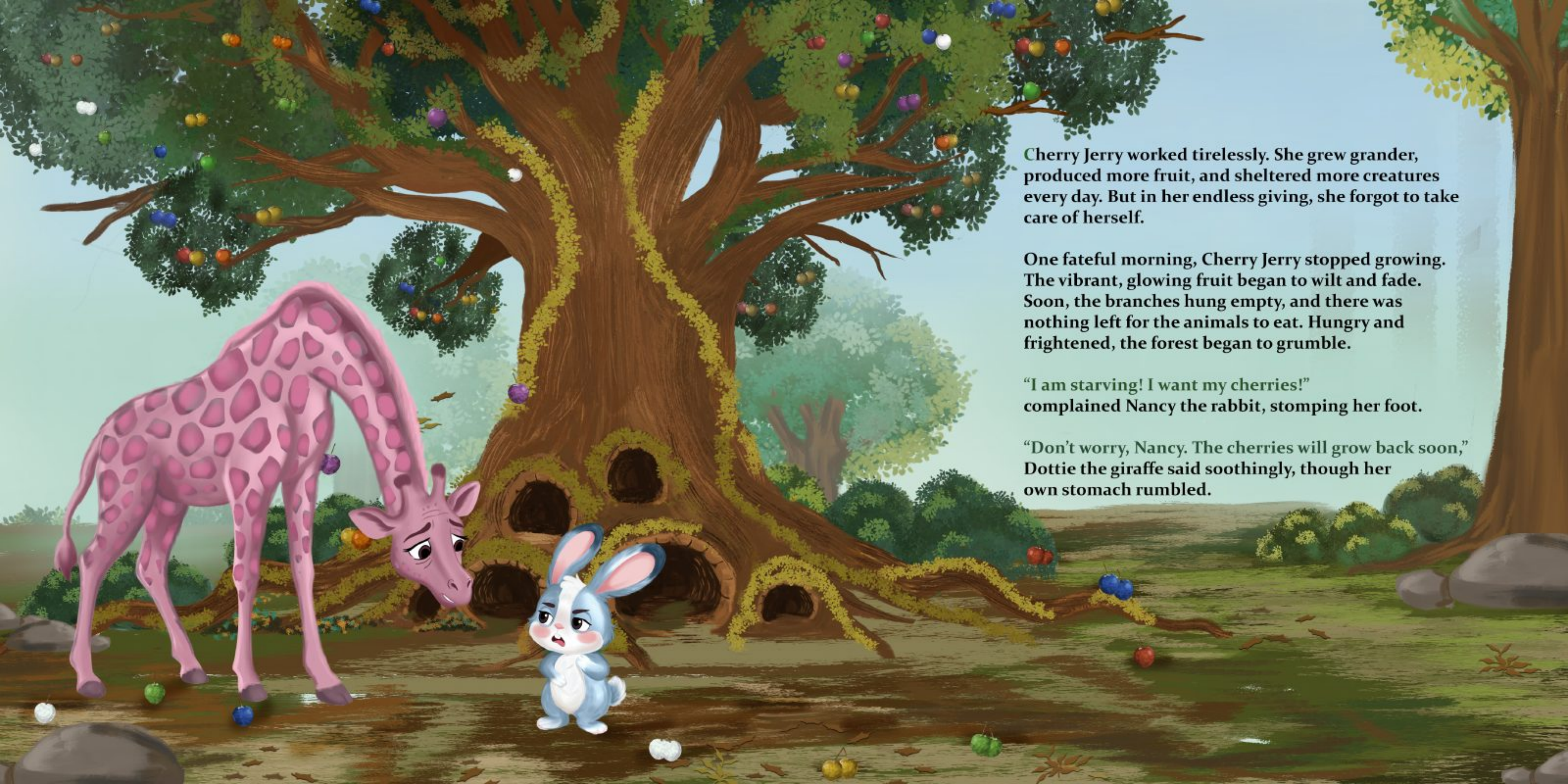


**Under her protective branches
lived six inseparable friends:**



- Dottie the giraffe, who was kind, funny, loved berries, and always looked out for others.
- Mona the monkey, who was wildly energetic, playful, and happiest when she was swinging through the branches with her friends.
- Nancy the rabbit, who could become terribly grumpy when she was tired or hungry, but still had a very sweet heart.

- Bumpy the camel, who was strong, steady, generous, and incredibly patient.
- Voz the bird, who loved to sing, dance, and fly high into the blue sky.
- Knotty was wonderfully playful and clever. But he had a peculiar habit:
*whenever an anxious thought popped into his head,
his body would twist into a tight, tangled knot.*



Cherry Jerry worked tirelessly. She grew grander, produced more fruit, and sheltered more creatures every day. But in her endless giving, she forgot to take care of herself.

One fateful morning, Cherry Jerry stopped growing. The vibrant, glowing fruit began to wilt and fade. Soon, the branches hung empty, and there was nothing left for the animals to eat. Hungry and frightened, the forest began to grumble.

"I am starving! I want my cherries!" complained Nancy the rabbit, stomping her foot.

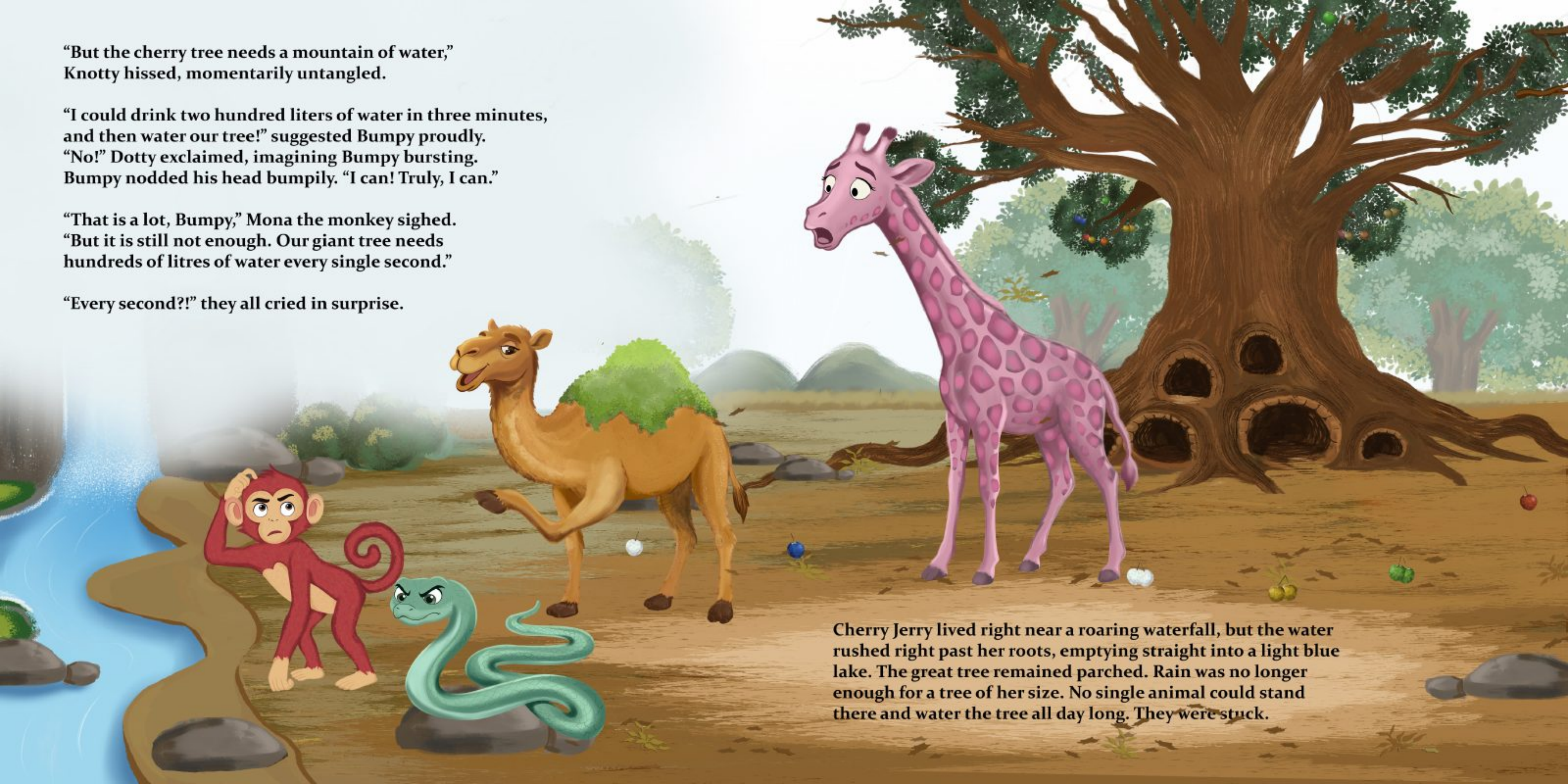
"Don't worry, Nancy. The cherries will grow back soon," Dottie the giraffe said soothingly, though her own stomach rumbled.

“But the cherry tree needs a mountain of water,” Knotty hissed, momentarily untangled.

“I could drink two hundred liters of water in three minutes, and then water our tree!” suggested Bumpy proudly.
“No!” Dotty exclaimed, imagining Bumpy bursting.
Bumpy nodded his head bumpily. “I can! Truly, I can.”

“That is a lot, Bumpy,” Mona the monkey sighed.
“But it is still not enough. Our giant tree needs hundreds of litres of water every single second.”

“Every second?!” they all cried in surprise.



Cherry Jerry lived right near a roaring waterfall, but the water rushed right past her roots, emptying straight into a light blue lake. The great tree remained parched. Rain was no longer enough for a tree of her size. No single animal could stand there and water the tree all day long. They were stuck.



Voz the bird was the most scared of all.
she felt too small, too fragile to help a tree so giant.
That night, her throat was tight; she could not sing
a single note.

As she sat quietly in her dark hollow inside Cherry Jerry's
trunk, a memory flickered in her mind.

The next morning, Voz gathered her friends.

"You know, our world has not always been this peaceful,"
she whispered, sharing a secret she had never told a soul.

"When I was a tiny chick, many years ago, there were many
humans on Earth. But they were always fighting. They hurt
each other, and they hurt us, too. The humans chopped down
the great forests and dried up the land with their misuse."

The friends sat perfectly still. For the first time, even grumpy
Nancy did not make a sound.

"I was only a little bird,
and I was terrified," Voz continued,
her voice trembling.

"But my mother hid me deep in a hollow right here
in Cherry Jerry's trunk. She wrapped her wings
tight around me, and she sang a lullaby."

*Little bird, little bird,
you are never too small.
When we take care of each other,
there is enough love for all.*

Voz took a deep breath.

"Our forest was the only one
that survived because we had
Cherry Jerry. She fed us her
magical fruit so we did not have
to fight each other to survive.
The old world ended, the forest
grew back, and Cherry Jerry
grew into the giant she is today.
She took care of us then. Now, it
is our turn to take care of her."

Voz's eyes brightened.

"When I was flying far beyond
the mountains, I saw that
humans water their vast farms
using machines. Even the ones
who break things can teach us
how to mend them."

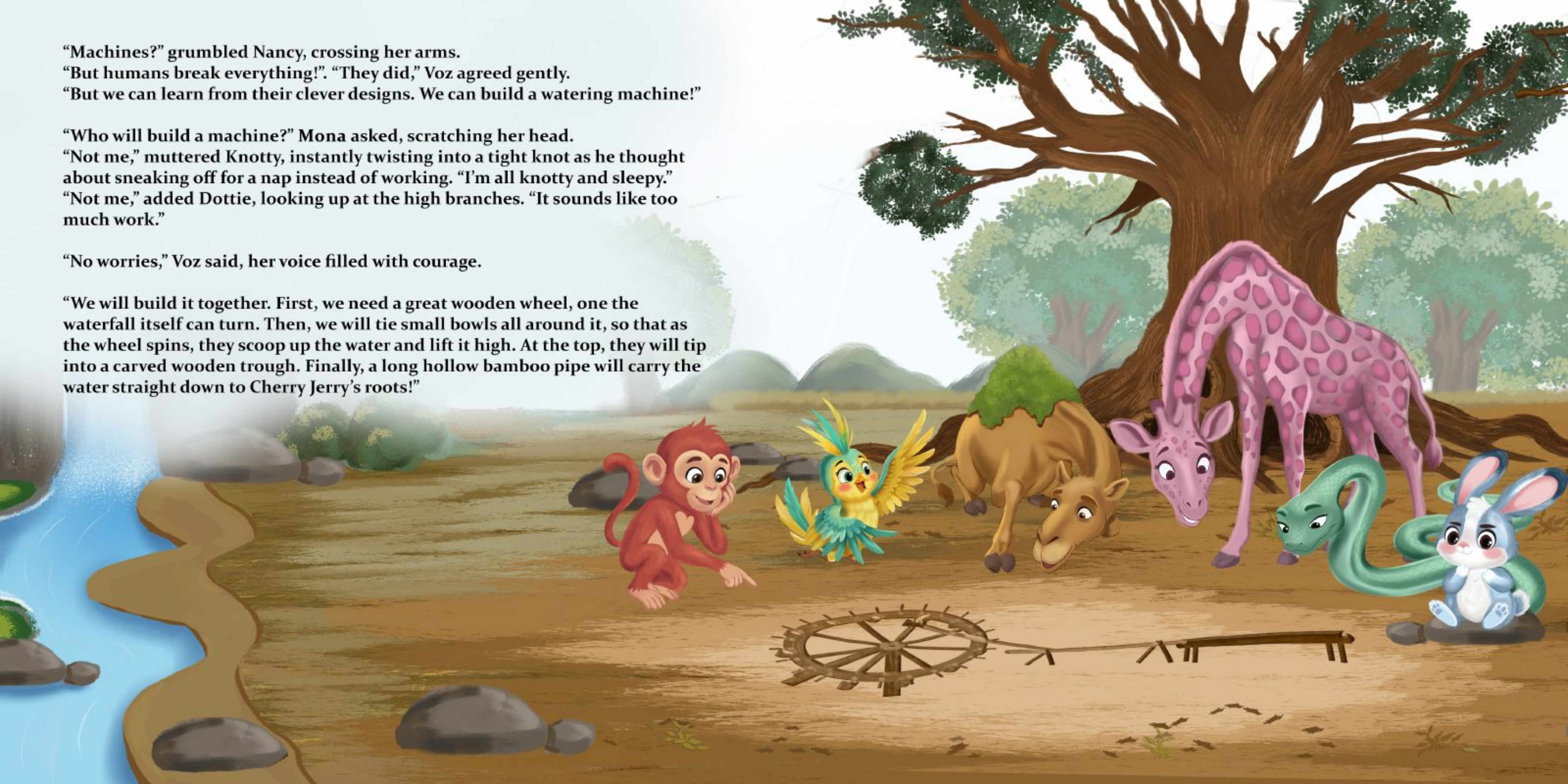


“Machines?” grumbled Nancy, crossing her arms.
“But humans break everything!”. “They did,” Voz agreed gently.
“But we can learn from their clever designs. We can build a watering machine!”

“Who will build a machine?” Mona asked, scratching her head.
“Not me,” muttered Knotty, instantly twisting into a tight knot as he thought about sneaking off for a nap instead of working. “I’m all knotty and sleepy.”
“Not me,” added Dottie, looking up at the high branches. “It sounds like too much work.”

“No worries,” Voz said, her voice filled with courage.

“We will build it together. First, we need a great wooden wheel, one the waterfall itself can turn. Then, we will tie small bowls all around it, so that as the wheel spins, they scoop up the water and lift it high. At the top, they will tip into a carved wooden trough. Finally, a long hollow bamboo pipe will carry the water straight down to Cherry Jerry’s roots!”



Inspired by Voz, the animals threw themselves into the hard work.

Voz flew like an arrow toward a forgotten village, swooping down to find an old bucket and a handful of small bowls left behind, and zoomed all the way back. Nancy hopped tirelessly through the thickets for hours, searching for the perfect, long, hollow bamboo stalks.

It was exhausting, but she refused to give up.



Knotty slithered through the slick mud, using his tail to trace out the exact measurements for the wheel.

Bumpy used his immense strength to carry heavy logs on his back for the wheel and the trough, while Mona swung through the canopy, tying the small bowls securely around the wheel with thick, sturdy vines. Dottie stood tall, using her long neck like a crane to guide the carved trough into place.

For twenty long days, they pooled their minds and muscles together.

On the twentieth evening, the machine was finished. The waterfall pushed against the great wooden wheel, and with a loud CLACK, it began to turn. The little bowls dipped into the rushing water, one by one, lifting it upward toward the carved trough at the top.

A tiny, weak trickle of water dripped onto the dry roots. "It has to be faster!" cried Nancy, wiping sweat from her brow. "It's barely a drop!"

"Patience, everybody. Trust the process. It will happen," Voz said calmly.

Voz flew up to Cherry Jerry's highest, bare branch. She looked out over the vast forest, took a deep breath, and began to sing her mother's song with all the love in her heart:



*Little bird, little bird,
you are never too small.
When we take care of each other,
there is enough love for all.*

She was not too small. She had never been too small.

As her voice carried through the forest, everyone tried once more. Knotty straightened the blocked channel. Mona tightened the vines. Bumpy braced the wheel. Nancy cleared the little waterways around the roots. Dottie guided the final pipe into place. Then: WHIRRRR!

The wooden wheel spun properly at last. Water rushed up through the little bowls, poured into the trough, and gushed down the bamboo pipe, drenching Cherry Jerry's thirsty roots in a magnificent splash. The giant tree shivered. Her bark crackled softly.

"Hello... did I just have a very scary nightmare?" mumbled a deep, gentle voice. Cherry Jerry was awake!



The forest erupted into pure joy. The birds burst into song. Knotty was so happy he did a wild, looping snake dance without tying himself up. Nancy hopped so high she looked like she might touch the stars.

"It's absolute magic!" Mona cheered.

"It wasn't just magic," Voz said, landing softly on Mona's shoulder.

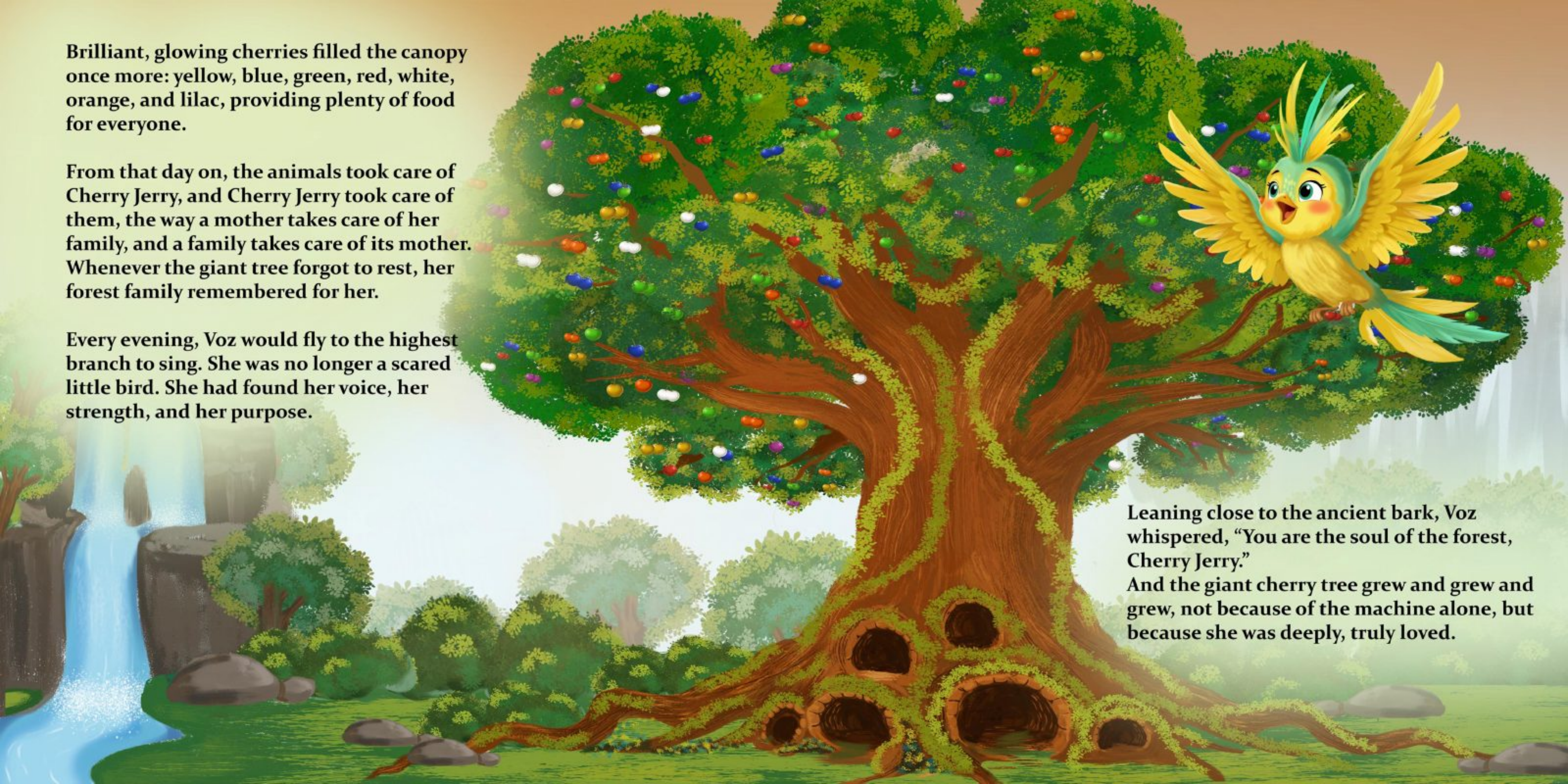
"It was all of us, together."

Brilliant, glowing cherries filled the canopy once more: yellow, blue, green, red, white, orange, and lilac, providing plenty of food for everyone.

From that day on, the animals took care of Cherry Jerry, and Cherry Jerry took care of them, the way a mother takes care of her family, and a family takes care of its mother. Whenever the giant tree forgot to rest, her forest family remembered for her.

Every evening, Voz would fly to the highest branch to sing. She was no longer a scared little bird. She had found her voice, her strength, and her purpose.

Leaning close to the ancient bark, Voz whispered, "You are the soul of the forest, Cherry Jerry."
And the giant cherry tree grew and grew and grew, not because of the machine alone, but because she was deeply, truly loved.



MUMMA'S LULLABY

*Little bird, little bird,
you are never too small.*

*When we take care of each other,
there is enough love for all.*



THE STORY BEHIND THE BOOK

I wrote this book to make children happy and to remind them to be kind, especially to their mothers. I feel that everyone has a little “monster” that appears from time to time. It may show up when we are angry, tired, hungry, worried, frightened, or overwhelmed.

The important thing is to recognize that monster, understand what wakes it up, and learn what helps it calm down. Sometimes that means resting. Sometimes it means moving, singing, talking, laughing, or asking someone we love for help.

Mums spend so much time helping their children with their big feelings that they can forget to look after their own. I want this story to remind everyone, children and grown-ups, to find the things that make them happy and make a little time for those things too.

We can try to be like Voz as much as possible: happy, brave, and full of song. But it is also okay to feel like Knotty, Dottie, Nancy, Mona, or Bumpy sometimes. Every mood has something to teach us. What matters is learning how to find our way back to ourselves.



ASHIMA AND VAANI

This is a mama-and-baby story, but in many ways, it is everybody's story. I love my mama more than anything in this world, in the galaxy, and in the whole universe. I am her princess, and she is my queen. To me, my mama is like a superwoman. She seems to take care of everything for everyone:

- Our home
- Our shopping
- Our gifts
- Our food
- Our holiday plans
- Our playdates
- Birthdays
- Our clothes
- Almost everything else we can think of.

She also looks after Papa, our family, and my grandparents. She is the person I want to be like when I grow up.

THE MAIN MESSAGE

*Sing and be happy.
Hum and be happy.
Fly and be happy.
Just be happy.*

THE PURPOSE OF THE BOOK

I wanted to write a book, but I knew many children had already written books. I wanted mine to do something more: I wanted it to bring happiness to other children.

When I went to Manzil, I met children who were different from me in many ways. Some spoke differently. Some did not speak at all. Some were very friendly, while others were shy. I began to think that, since everybody has their own little monsters and moods, maybe they do too.

That is why I want to bring them into my forest, a place filled with different animals, different personalities, and different feelings. I want children to understand that it is okay to have moods. It is okay to feel angry, anxious, tired, excited, playful, or quiet. And it is easier to face those feelings when we have friends beside us.

The children at Manzil taught me that “can’t” does not have to be the end of a sentence. With support, patience, creativity, and friendship, people can surprise themselves with what they are able to do.

Just like my friends and me, I want to bring my forest to life at Manzil so children can sing, paint, climb, learn, play, and find more reasons to be happy.

I am also designing a play area with a climbing wall and a Cherry Jerry Tree of Knowledge, where children can sit, learn, imagine, and discover how to become their own kind of superheroes: happy, brave, and better able to understand and calm their monsters.

